VIKISEWS

SILHOUETTE SHAPES AND EASE ALLOWANCES

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An initial examination of a garment gives us a visual impression determined by a garment's volume, silhouette, and lines. Dimensions of a garment and its parts depend on an individual's body measurements and the added amount of garment ease. The difference between the body measurements and the inner dimensions of a garment is called wearing ease allowance.

Ease allowance is necessary as it allows the wearer to move freely and breath normally. In fact, if a garment has no ease allowance added, it feels like a "second skin". The exceptions are garments made from stretchy materials, such as knits, stretch fabrics, etc. In this case, the garment has no ease or the ease is negative.

As a rule, wearing ease is characterised by the extent to which a garment fits the figure; it determines the construction, volume, and silhouette of a garment.

Let's consider the basic silhouette shapes.

FITTED-WAIST SILHOUETTE

A characteristic feature of the fitted-waist silhouette is a snug fit at the waist. At the same time, the fit at the top and bottom parts of a garment may vary from tight to loose. The waistline is always positioned at the natural waist level.

For fitted-waist garments, the waistline ease is generally minimal, while the bust ease and hipline ease vary depending of the garment design.

CLOSE-FITTING SILHOUETTE

A close-fitting garment usually fits close to the body at the bust, waist, and hips. It also often fits tight at the arms and legs. The waist is accentuated with darts and princess seams, as well as thanks to stretchy fabrics. A close-fitting silhouette draws attention to the body and highlights body features. In such a garment, the silhouette follows each and every curve of the body.

The amount of ease along all silhouette lines is minimal and may even become negative if a garment is made from stretchy fabric. It depends on the stretch properties of the fabric.

SEMI-FITTED SILHOUETTE

A semi-fitted silhouette falls in between two other types, close-fitting and straight. A semi-fitted garment follows the contours of the body, yet, due to its moderate fit, conceals the body features that you don't want to show. There is always some extra room between the body and garment. The defined waistline doesn't always correspond to the natural waist on the figure, but may be located above or below it.

A semi-fitted garment suggests the use of shaping elements, such as bust darts to provide space for breasts, or shoulder darts to fit the shoulder blades. As for the waist darts, a garment can be designed either with small waist darts or without them at all.

STRAIGHT SILHOUETTE

A straight silhouette graphically resembles a rectangle or square shape. The volume of a garment may vary from an obvious oversized fit to a more fitted silhouette. Straight garments are often shaped only with bust darts, or have no darts at all. The fit is loose and relaxed.

This silhouette type suggests adding the largest amount of ease at the waist.

O-SHAPE (OVAL) SILHOUETTE

An oval silhouette is a variation of a straight silhouette. It is identified by a soft outline of the figure — a rounded shoulder line, a loose shape, and tapering towards the bottom. The garment is the widest at the bust, waist, abdomen area, and hips.

A-LINE (TRAPEZE) SILHOUETTE

A trapeze silhouette flares down from the shoulder line, armscye line, or from under the bust. In bottom garments, the flare starts at the waistline. The amount of flare varies from slight to exaggerated. An A-line garment may be loose along its entire length without emphasis on the waist.

When analysing the silhouette shape of a reference garment, i.e. studying an image of a garment, we can estimate the amount of ease that depends on how fitted the garment is along the silhouette lines at the bust, waist, and hips.